

TRULY OVER THE TOP

Endless options, viewing flexibility and exciting horizons to discover—OTT entertainment platforms have left Indians spoilt for choice

By SUHANI SINGH

THE DRUDGERY

For the longest time, the average Indian household was engaged in an everlasting feud—for control of the TV remote. With only 10 per cent of the population interested in and able to go to the cinema, it was a significant battle to win. Stereotypically, dads watched news and sports, moms their mushy soaps and kids had their hours restricted and viewing monitored. By the 2010s, Indians tired of the monotonous TV fare, and hungry for fresher programming, had already been turning to YouTube to get their fix of entertainment. But, barring the odd The Viral Fever (TVF) web series like *Pitchers* and *Permanent Roommates*, options for desi fare were limited to watching what had already run on television.

OTT PLATFORMS
Launched in *2013, with SonyLIV*

Achievement: 100 million Indians have access to OTTs

EASE OF LIVING

This state of affairs finally ended with the entry of streaming, aka OTT (over the top) platforms, with each family member empowered to make their own choice on their digital device—phone, tablet, computer or smart TV. It was in such a market that Sony launched SonyLIV, its streaming arm, in 2013 and Star soon followed with HotStar. Entertainment was no longer only a communal experience as users could watch their preferred content at their time of choice.

However, it wasn't until Netflix and Amazon Prime Video entered India in 2016 that the quest for eyeballs heated up and programming was truly revolutionised. The launch of Indian web-only originals like *Sacred Games* led to the rise of long-format storytelling; words like "binge-watch" and "skip intro" entered our lexicon, password sharing became routine, and producers, directors and writers—now liberated from the diktats of the box office—began to push the envelope. What the two international players also did is expose the viewer to a wide array of shows and films beyond English. Just like that, Indians were hooked to Netflix's Spanish show *Money Heist* as they were to its Korean drama *Squid Game*. Such was the impact that TV's pro-